

Unit 2: Gender, Race, and Violence

This unit explores the way our identities impact how we experience abuse and violence. Group participants will explore concepts of power, control, and violence through the following thematic questions:

- What is domestic violence? How does it relate to the ideas of power, control, and toxic masculinity?
- What is the cycle of abuse and violence, and how can I reflect on its presence in my life and relationships?
- How do my racial and cultural identities influence the way I relate to other people and the way other people relate to me?

Lesson 1: Domestic Violence 101

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

At this point, we've had conversations about gender roles, toxic masculinity, and power and control. Today's subject, domestic violence, is in many ways a culmination of those ideas. Domestic violence can take many forms, and today we're going to think through several manifestations of abuse.

First, I'd like to start with physical abuse. Often when people think about domestic violence, they have in mind a very narrow idea of what "counts." People tend to know that hitting, punching, and kicking are physical abuse, but they might not think of things like pinching, hair pulling, scratching, or even driving recklessly.

When thinking about domestic violence, physical abuse is when someone uses non-consensual physical force against someone in any capacity, usually in an attempt to control their partner or family member. With this definition in mind, what are some other examples of physical abuse you can think of?

- Pushing
- Throwing things

- Choking
- Restraining someone physically
- Sexual violence

(If not mentioned among the responses, bring this example up yourself. Note for the group that any sexual act without freely and enthusiastically-given consent is an example of physical and sexual abuse.)

Physical abuse is not the only kind of domestic violence. Emotional and verbal abuse can be every bit as traumatic and impactful as physical abuse—potentially even more traumatic. Emotional and verbal abuse can be harder to spot, especially because sometimes part of the abuse is in convincing someone that there is no abuse. We're going to take a look at a chart that will help us understand some of the ways emotional abuse can operate within a relationship.

Handout 3: Domestic Violence Chart

From the chart:

Let's go through these categories and discuss their definitions. Then, it will be your job to come up with examples for each category.

Threats and intimidation

Threats are often a precursor to physical violence. Threatening to hurt a partner, threatening to leave if certain demands aren't met, threatening suicide if a partner leaves—these are all abusive methods of controlling someone. Intimidation works much the same way, except sometimes intimidation is unspoken. Violently destroying objects, showing weapons or methods of violence, abusing pets in the home: these actions all carry the suggestion that at any time, the violence could be translated to someone in the home.

Financial control

When total control of the financial decisions rests with one partner or family member, there is potential for abuse. We live in a culture where money often means mobility, access, and opportunity: Preventing someone from making, keeping, or utilizing money and household income can be a way of controlling them and their movements.

Weaponizing children and dependents

Children are the most vulnerable among us in situations of abuse. Often, in addition to experiencing and witnessing abuse, children in a home where domestic violence is happening can be used as pawns and bargaining objects. Controlling someone by threatening to take someone's children away, threatening to harm children, or using children as a go-between are ways of maintaining power and control in a relationship.

Isolation and silent treatment

One of the ways abusive situations can sustain themselves is by isolating partners or family members from their communities, families, and friends. The fewer people who can influence someone who is being abused, the easier it is to continue cycles of violence and abuse. Often incorporating jealousy, isolation can mean forbidding a partner to see friends or family, forbidding coming and going from the home freely, and even limiting exposure to knowledge and media that may threaten the power and authority of the partner.

The silent treatment works a bit differently. It's the refusal to engage verbally with a partner, often despite being in the same physical space. Someone "stonewalling" in this way can make a partner feel invisible. That doesn't mean that every time someone ignores someone else it's abusive, but when the silent treatment operates in the relationship as a method of punishment to make a partner uncertain and anxious and more easily controlled, it is a damaging part of a pattern of abuse.

Blaming and gaslighting

I referenced gaslighting earlier when I mentioned that sometimes in abusive situations, people being abused are convinced that their own experience of abuse is imagined or invalid. Gaslighting is a practice of convincing someone that their view of reality is flawed, untrue, or unbelievable. In the context of domestic violence, that can be an outright denial that abuse ever happened, a minimization of the history of abuse, or making someone uncertain of their own reality or mental stability in order to disrupt their narrative of the abuse.

Blaming is easier to identify. When we blame people, we put all of the responsibility for a situation, or even our own actions, on their shoulders. Someone doing a lot of blaming will begin a lot of sentences with "You..." For example, "You made me do this,"

“you made me think that,” “you always,” and “you never.” A person using blame in abuse doesn’t take accountability.

Insults and put-downs

Insults and put-downs are often what come to mind first when we think of verbal abuse: words that make someone feel bad about themselves, attacks on their character and self-esteem, humiliating someone and calling them names. These tactics serve to shatter someone’s self-esteem and confidence, leaving them more susceptible to, and even tolerant of, abuse.

With these definitions in mind, I want you to go through this chart. In the blank spaces provided under each category, write an example of a behavior, situation, or hypothetical quote that represents the concept in that category. (Note: Providing your own examples for the group may be helpful in grounding them. For example, “Under blaming and gaslighting, I wrote ‘It’s your fault we argue.’ What else is a statement of blame or gaslighting?”)

Group Sharing

Questions for consideration:

- *Who has a good example for threatening and intimidating behavior?*
- *What about financial control? Who imagined what that might look or sound like?*
- *How about children? How might they be used against someone in an abusive situation?*
- *How about isolation? What might that look like?*
- *Who can think of an example of gaslighting, one of the more difficult concepts?*
- *What is the role of verbal abuse and put-downs in domestic abuse?*
- *What was challenging about filling out the domestic violence chart?*
- *Did you learn something new or different about abuse?*
- *Do you have any questions about the ideas we covered today?*

Lesson 2: Power, Control, and Cycles of Violence

Lesson Script

Power and control came up a lot in our previous session. When we were examining different kinds of abuse and abusive behaviors, we discovered that most of them were attempts to maintain power and control in a relationship.

Power and control can be difficult to discuss because they are abstract concepts. One of the ways we can understand the way people try to control and hold power in their environments is to think about what might motivate someone to seek control and power in the first place.

Some say that this behavior is rooted in fear—that when people attempt to control people and surroundings they are motivated by a deep anxiety that they will lose control over their lives and be abandoned by others.

Review

First, let's take a moment to review what we learned and discussed last session. We went over different forms of abuse, and those concepts are very important for the work we'll be doing.

- Are there any examples we didn't hear that you wanted to share from your charts?
- Were there concepts from the chart that you didn't understand or want to clarify?
- Are there things you think are abusive that the chart doesn't address?
- How about physical and sexual violence? Do we understand the role violence plays in abuse?

We're going to look at another visual model to help make sense of abusive patterns.

Attempts to overpower and control partners and family members can look many different ways—especially when wielded through a practice of toxic masculinity. As we discussed in our conversation about domestic violence, the methods of abuse are varied. Despite this variability, the pattern of abuse and maintenance of power and control often looks similar.

Handout 4: Cycle of Abuse

Take a look at this depiction of the cycle of abuse. We can start at the top, with violence, and follow the arrow to see that often, outbursts of physical, sexual, or emotional violence are followed by periods of relative peace. This means that sometimes physical abuse stops for a period of time, or lessens significantly. Verbal abuse stops, or sometimes even becomes the opposite: praise and apologies and expressions of guilt for the abuse are common.

But after a little while, the tension builds again. Patience seems limited, tempers rise, and altercations escalate until there is another incident of violence. Then, the cycle begins again.

Individual Reflection

We're going to take a moment to individually reflect on this cycle. Have you seen this cycle show up in your own life, or in the lives of people close to you? What did it look and feel like? What signs do you notice that indicate you're in the midst of this cycle?

Write down your thoughts and be prepared to share some of your ideas with the larger group.

Large Group Discussion

- *Did this cycle resonate with you or reflect your experiences?*
- *What do you notice when you're in this cycle?*
- *How does it feel to participate in this cycle?*
- *Are there parts of the cycle that don't match up with your experiences?*
- *Are there any questions about power, control, or the cycle of abuse?*

Lesson 3: Violence and Culture

Lesson Script

Our cultural backgrounds can operate as a lens through which we see the world. Race, gender, nationality, religion— all of these parts of our identity shape our cultural context. We've discussed violence, power, and abuse during this unit, and now we're going to spend some time thinking about how culture influences the way we think about violence.

Take a moment to reflect and write about the questions on Handout 5.

Handout 5: Violence and Culture

Large Group Discussion

- *Did you know right away what you wanted to write about, or did it take some thought?*
- *How have cultural norms or ideas influenced the way you think about violence or abuse? (If additional prompting is needed: What about racial norms? Religious expectations?)*
- *What makes someone powerful in your culture?*
- *What values does your culture have around family and relationships?*
- *What do healthy, ideal relationships look like in your cultural context?*